Venus (The Hottest Planet)



Venus

Venus is the second planet from the Sun. It is called the **Earth's twin**, as it is almost the same size as the Earth. It has the longest rotation period (243 days) among the planets in the Solar system. It rotates in the opposite direction to all other planets, except Uranus. It has no natural satellites, like Mercury. It is named after the Roman goddess of love and beauty. It is often visible in the mornings and the evenings and so it is frequently called as the **Morning Star** and the **Evening Star**. After the Moon, it is the brightest natural object in the night sky.

HOTS: Even though Mercury is the nearest planet to the Sun, Venus is the hottest one. Guess why?

Earth (The Living Planet)



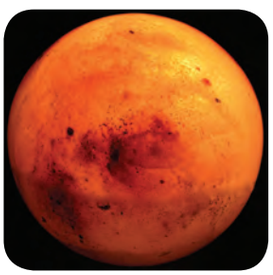
Earth

The Earth is the third planet from the Sun and the fifth largest planet in the solar system. It is called the 'blue planet' or 'watery planet' because three-fourth of the Earth is covered by water. The Earth is the only planet in the solar system which is not named after any Greek or Roman deity. It is the only planet known to support life. Life is possible on Earth because of the presence of land, air and water. The polar diameter of the Earth is 12,714 km and the equatorial diameter is 12,756 km. The Earth revolves around the Sun at a speed of about 30 km per second. The only natural satellite of the Earth is the Moon.



The distance between the Sun and the Earth is about 150 million kilometre. A flight flying at a speed of 800 km per hour from the Earth would take 21 years to reach the Sun.

Mars (The Red Planet)



Mars

Mars is the fourth planet from the Sun and the second smallest planet in the solar system, after Mercury. It is named after the Roman God of war. It appears red in colour due to the presence of iron oxide on its surface. So, it is often described as the **Red Planet**. It has a thin atmosphere. It also has polar ice caps like the Earth.

On 24th September, 2014 Mangalyan (Mars Orbiter Mission - MOM), launched by the Indian Space Research Organization (ISRO), reached the orbit of Mars to analyze its atmosphere and topography. ISRO has now become the fourth space agency to reach Mars after the Soviet Space programme, NASA and the European Space Agency.

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